

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Archaeologist Nadia Yilmaz excavated a series of underground grain storage pits at a Neolithic settlement in central Turkey, dated to approximately 7000 BCE. Yilmaz observed that pits lined with a thin layer of pressed clay still contained well-preserved grain residue, while unlined pits at the same site contained only decomposed organic matter. Yilmaz concluded that the inhabitants intentionally applied clay linings as a preservation technique to protect stored grain from moisture and insect damage.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Yilmaz's conclusion?

A: The clay used in the pit linings was sourced from a riverbed located over three kilometers from the settlement, and fingerprint impressions on the clay surface indicate it was shaped and pressed into place by hand

B: Similar clay deposits occur naturally in the soil surrounding several of the storage pits, though these natural deposits are thinner and less uniform than the linings Yilmaz identified

C: Grain storage pits from the same period at other Neolithic sites in the region do not contain clay linings of any kind

D: The preserved grain residue found in the lined pits was identified as emmer wheat, one of the earliest domesticated cereal crops in the ancient Near East

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Yilmaz claims the clay lining was INTENTIONAL. A shows the clay was transported from 3 km away and shaped by hand -- proving deliberate application. B is the strongest trap: natural clay deposits near the pits suggest the lining could have formed without human action. C shows other sites lacked linings but does not prove these were intentional. TRICK: 'Intentional human action' claims are supported by evidence of effort (transport, shaping) that cannot occur naturally.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Psychologist Alan Nyong'o found that university students who voluntarily listened to subject-related podcasts before attending lectures scored an average of 10 percent higher on course examinations than students who did not listen to podcasts. Nyong'o concluded that supplementary podcast listening improves students' academic performance by providing additional exposure to course material.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Nyong'o's conclusion?

A: The podcasts recommended by Nyong'o covered topics that overlapped substantially with the course lecture material rather than introducing new content

B: Students who chose to listen to podcasts were also found to spend significantly more hours per week studying, attending office hours, and completing optional practice problems than students who did not listen to podcasts

C: A majority of students surveyed said they found the recommended podcasts engaging and easy to follow

D: Students who listened to podcasts scored higher on examinations across all major topic areas covered in the course, not just on topics that were addressed in the podcasts

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Nyong'o concludes podcasts caused better scores. B reveals self-selection: podcast listeners also studied more, attended office hours, and did extra practice. These habits, not the podcasts, could drive the 10 percent advantage. A is tempting but overlap does not weaken the claim (repeated exposure could still help). D actually strengthens. TRICK: When participation is voluntary, the volunteers usually differ from non-volunteers in ways that independently affect the outcome.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Ecologist Tomoko Sato documented that a population of stickleback fish in Lake Vostok, British Columbia, has increased in average body length by 18 percent over the past thirty years. Sato noted that a species of diving beetle--a predator of sticklebacks--was introduced to the lake approximately thirty-five years ago. Sato proposed that the beetle's introduction drove evolutionary selection for larger body size in the stickleback population, since larger fish would be more difficult for the beetles to capture and consume.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Sato's proposed mechanism?

A: The diving beetle population in Lake Vostok has remained stable over the past thirty years, showing no significant increase or decrease in numbers

B: Stickleback populations in nearby lakes that lack diving beetles have shown no significant change in average body length over the same thirty-year period

C: Field observations and laboratory feeding trials confirmed that diving beetles successfully captured and consumed small sticklebacks at five times the rate of large sticklebacks, creating a measurable survival advantage for larger individuals

D: Genetic analysis of the Lake Vostok sticklebacks revealed several gene variants associated with body size that are more common in this population than in stickleback populations in other lakes

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Sato claims beetles drove selection for larger size because larger fish are harder to catch. C confirms the critical mechanism: beetles actually DO prey disproportionately on small fish, creating a survival advantage for large ones. B is tempting (other lakes show no change) but only rules out an alternative cause -- it does not confirm the beetle predation mechanism. D shows genetic change but not that beetles caused it. TRICK: Evolutionary selection claims require evidence that the proposed selective agent actually favors the trait in question.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Economist Gloria Mensah compared crime statistics and public infrastructure data across 50 cities in a developed nation. Mensah found that cities with more public libraries per capita had significantly lower property crime rates. Mensah concluded that public libraries reduce property crime by providing safe gathering spaces, educational resources, and constructive activities for at-risk populations.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Mensah's conclusion?

A: Cities with more libraries per capita also tend to have larger overall municipal budgets, which fund a wider range of public services including libraries

B: Property crime rates in the 50 cities had been declining for over a decade before the study period, following a national trend

C: The libraries in cities with low crime rates were located primarily in affluent neighborhoods rather than in high-crime areas

D: Individual-level data from household surveys revealed that residents who used public libraries were no less likely to commit property crimes than residents who did not, and that the lower crime rates in library-rich cities were attributable to those cities' higher median incomes and lower poverty rates

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Mensah uses city-level data to claim libraries reduce crime. D provides individual-level evidence showing library users are NOT less likely to commit crimes -- the city-level pattern is driven by income and poverty differences, not libraries. A introduces a budget confound but does not directly disprove the library-crime link. C is strong but addresses location rather than causation. TRICK: When a conclusion draws individual-level claims from aggregate data, individual-level evidence disproving the link is the most direct weakener (ecological fallacy).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Botanist Clara Engstrom studied a species of cactus in the Sonoran Desert that opens its flowers exclusively between dusk and midnight before closing them by dawn. Engstrom proposed that the cactus has evolved this nocturnal flowering pattern specifically to attract pollination by hawkmoths, which are most active during the early nighttime hours.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Engstrom's proposal?

A: Infrared camera traps positioned near the cacti recorded hawkmoths visiting the open flowers on 89 percent of observed nights, and pollen from the cactus was found on the bodies of captured hawkmoths, while no other pollinator species were recorded visiting the flowers

B: The cactus flowers produce a strong, sweet fragrance that intensifies during the hours they are open and diminishes significantly by daylight

C: Hawkmoths have been documented as important pollinators for several other plant species in the Sonoran Desert that also flower at night

D: The cactus species is found only in areas of the Sonoran Desert where hawkmoth populations are known to be present

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Engstrom proposes nocturnal flowering evolved to attract hawkmoths. A provides direct proof: hawkmoths actually visit the flowers nearly every night AND carry the pollen, with no other pollinators observed. B and D are consistent with the hypothesis but do not confirm actual pollination. C shows hawkmoths pollinate other species but not necessarily this one.

TRICK: Behavioral hypotheses about 'evolved to attract X' are best supported by direct observation of X actually performing the function.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Epidemiologist Hana Okwu analyzed data from a ten-year health survey of 50,000 adults. Okwu found that participants who reported taking a daily fish oil supplement had a 22 percent lower incidence of cardiovascular disease compared to participants who did not take fish oil supplements. Okwu concluded that fish oil supplementation provides a protective effect against cardiovascular disease.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Okwu's conclusion?

A: Several randomized controlled trials of fish oil supplementation conducted in other countries have produced inconsistent results, with some showing modest benefits and others showing no effect

B: Participants who took fish oil supplements were also found to exercise more frequently, eat more fruits and vegetables, smoke less, and attend preventive medical appointments at higher rates than non-supplement users, and after statistically adjusting for these behavioral differences, the association between fish oil use and cardiovascular disease disappeared entirely

C: The brand of fish oil supplement most commonly used by survey participants contained a lower concentration of omega-3 fatty acids than the dosage used in most clinical trials

D: Participants who took fish oil supplements and participants who did not were similar in age, gender distribution, and baseline body mass index at the start of the survey

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Okwu concludes fish oil protects against heart disease. B reveals healthy user bias: supplement users also exercise more, eat better, smoke less, and see doctors more. After adjusting for these, the fish oil effect vanishes -- proving the lifestyle differences, not the supplement, drove the results. A is tempting (mixed evidence elsewhere) but does not directly address THIS study. D seems to support the study but only controls for some variables. TRICK: 'Healthy user bias' means people who take supplements tend to be healthier in many ways. If adjusting for those behaviors eliminates the effect, the supplement is not the cause.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Sociologist Omar Bah proposed that neighborhood walkability -- the presence of sidewalks, crosswalks, and pedestrian-friendly streets -- increases civic participation such as voting, volunteering, and attending community meetings. Critics argue that people who are already civically engaged may simply choose to live in walkable neighborhoods, making the observed association a product of self-selection rather than a causal effect of walkability.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Bah's claim over the self-selection critique?

A: Residents of walkable neighborhoods reported higher levels of trust in their neighbors than residents of car-dependent neighborhoods, according to a survey conducted across twelve cities

B: The proportion of residents who described themselves as 'very interested in local politics' was similar in walkable and non-walkable neighborhoods before any infrastructure changes were made

C: In neighborhoods where municipal construction projects converted car-dependent streets into pedestrian-friendly ones, civic participation rates among long-term residents who had moved in before the conversion increased significantly compared to rates among similar residents in neighborhoods where no conversion occurred

D: Cities that invested more in pedestrian infrastructure also invested more in public transit and affordable housing, creating multiple pathways to community engagement

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: The self-selection critique says engaged people choose walkable areas. C defeats this by studying people who were ALREADY living there before the change -- they did not self-select into walkability. Their increased participation after the conversion must be caused by the walkability itself. B is tempting (similar baseline interest) but does not prove walkability caused the change. D introduces confounds. TRICK: Natural experiments -- where the variable changes around people who did not choose it -- are the strongest response to self-selection critiques.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Education researcher Priya Iyer found that middle school students who used colored highlighters while reading textbook chapters scored 15 percent higher on subsequent comprehension quizzes than students who read the same chapters without highlighters. Iyer concluded that the physical act of highlighting key passages improves reading comprehension by helping students identify and encode important information.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Iyer's conclusion?

- A: Students who used highlighters reported finding the reading assignments more enjoyable than students who read without highlighters
- B: The comprehension quizzes tested both factual recall and inferential reasoning, and the highlighting group scored higher on both types of questions
- C: Teachers at the school had not provided any specific instruction on effective highlighting strategies before the study began
- D: Students who used highlighters spent an average of 40 percent more time reading each chapter than students who read without highlighters, and a separate analysis showed that time spent reading was the single strongest predictor of quiz scores in both groups

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Iyer credits highlighting itself for better comprehension. D reveals that highlighters spent 40 percent more TIME reading, and time was the strongest predictor of scores. The improvement came from extra reading time, not the highlighting technique. A addresses enjoyment, not comprehension mechanism. B strengthens the finding's breadth. TRICK: When one group does an additional activity (highlighting), they inevitably spend more time on the material. If the outcome tracks time-on-task, the activity itself may be irrelevant.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Geneticist Kofi Asare found that a specific variant of the ACE gene was present in 78 percent of elite endurance athletes in a national sample but in only 30 percent of the general population. Asare proposed that this gene variant enhances endurance performance by increasing the efficiency of oxygen delivery to skeletal muscles during sustained exercise.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Asare's proposed mechanism?

A: Laboratory analysis showed that individuals carrying the ACE variant produced significantly higher levels of a protein that promotes capillary growth in muscle tissue, and physiological testing confirmed that carriers had 20 percent greater oxygen uptake in working muscles during prolonged exercise compared to non-carriers

B: The ACE variant was found at similarly elevated frequencies in elite endurance athletes from five different countries across three continents

C: Elite sprinters, whose events require explosive power rather than sustained endurance, did not carry the ACE variant at rates higher than the general population

D: A twin study found that identical twins were more similar in endurance performance than fraternal twins, indicating a substantial genetic component to endurance capacity

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Asare proposes a specific mechanism: ACE variant -> better oxygen delivery to muscles. A confirms both the molecular pathway (more capillary-growth protein) AND the physiological outcome (20 percent greater oxygen uptake). B shows the variant is common in athletes globally but does not test the mechanism. C supports specificity to endurance but not the oxygen pathway. D shows genetics matter but not which gene or mechanism. TRICK: Gene association claims require mechanistic evidence showing HOW the gene produces the effect, not just that the association exists across populations.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Political scientist Lena Dahl compared voter turnout rates across 30 democracies and found that countries using proportional representation (PR) electoral systems had average voter turnout rates 12 percentage points higher than countries using winner-take-all systems. Dahl concluded that PR systems cause higher voter turnout because they give voters a greater sense that their vote will translate into representation, thereby increasing motivation to participate.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Dahl's conclusion?

A: Several countries that switched from winner-take-all to proportional representation during the study period did not see immediate changes in voter turnout in the first election after the switch

B: The countries using PR systems in Dahl's sample also had automatic voter registration, election-day holidays, and publicly funded voter outreach campaigns, while most of the winner-take-all countries lacked these features, and a regression analysis showed that these institutional features, not the electoral system type, were the primary predictors of turnout differences

C: Voter turnout in PR countries varied substantially, with some PR countries having turnout rates below 60 percent and others above 90 percent

D: Survey data from voters in PR countries showed that a majority of respondents could not accurately describe how the PR system translated their votes into legislative seats

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Dahl credits the PR system for higher turnout. B shows PR countries also had registration, holidays, and outreach campaigns, and a regression analysis attributes the turnout difference to THOSE features, not the electoral system. A is tempting (no immediate change after switching) but could reflect a lag rather than no effect. D is interesting (voters don't understand PR) but misunderstanding the system does not prove it has no effect on turnout. TRICK: Cross-country comparisons are weakened when countries that share one feature (PR) also systematically differ in other features that independently predict the outcome.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Neuroscientist Ingrid Holm used brain imaging to compare bilingual adults who had learned a second language before age 10 with monolingual adults of the same age and education level. Holm found that bilingual adults had greater gray matter density in the anterior cingulate cortex (ACC), a brain region associated with cognitive control. Holm proposed that the demands of managing two languages cause structural growth in the ACC over time.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Holm's proposed causal claim?

A: Bilingual adults in the study also performed better than monolinguals on tasks requiring them to switch between different sets of rules, consistent with enhanced ACC function

B: Adults who spoke three or more languages had even greater ACC gray matter density than adults who spoke exactly two languages

C: A five-year longitudinal study of adults who began intensive second-language training as monolinguals showed measurable increases in ACC gray matter density over the training period, while a matched control group of monolinguals who did not undertake language training showed no change

D: The ACC is known to be one of several brain regions that can exhibit structural plasticity in response to sustained cognitive demands, based on studies of other trained skills such as musical performance

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Holm claims bilingualism CAUSES ACC growth. C provides longitudinal evidence: monolingual adults who BECAME bilingual showed ACC growth over time, while matched controls did not. This proves the direction of causation (language learning -> ACC growth, not pre-existing ACC differences -> language aptitude). A and B are consistent with the claim but remain cross-sectional. TRICK: 'X causes brain change Y' is best supported by longitudinal evidence showing Y develops AFTER people acquire X, not by cross-sectional comparisons (which cannot rule out pre-existing differences).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Education policy analyst Dario Restrepo compared standardized mathematics test scores in school districts that had adopted a new inquiry-based math curriculum with scores in districts that retained the traditional textbook-based curriculum. Restrepo found that adopting districts showed an average improvement of 6 percentile points over three years. Restrepo concluded that the inquiry-based curriculum is more effective at improving student mathematics achievement than the traditional approach.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Restrepo's conclusion?

A: The inquiry-based curriculum required teachers to complete 80 hours of professional development training before implementation, while the traditional curriculum required no additional training

B: Districts using the traditional curriculum also showed modest improvements in test scores over the same three-year period, though the improvements were smaller than those in adopting districts

C: Student survey data indicated that students in inquiry-based districts reported higher levels of engagement and enjoyment in mathematics classes

D: Districts that chose to adopt the inquiry-based curriculum were already among the highest-performing and best-funded districts in the state, with more experienced teachers and greater per-student spending, while districts that retained the traditional curriculum tended to be lower-performing with fewer resources

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Restrepo attributes the improvement to the curriculum. D reveals that adopting districts were already high-performing, well-funded, and had better teachers. Their improvement could reflect these advantages, not the curriculum. A is tempting (extra training could be a confound) but could also be part of the curriculum's design. B does not weaken the comparative advantage. TRICK: When adoption is voluntary, early adopters are systematically different from non-adopters. Any pre-existing advantage can masquerade as a treatment effect.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Marine biologist Rafael Costa studied coral reef ecosystems adjacent to a marine protected area (MPA) off the coast of Belize. Costa found that fish populations on reefs just outside the MPA boundary were 30 percent larger than fish populations on comparable reefs located farther from the MPA. Costa proposed that the MPA generates a 'spillover effect' in which fish populations that grow within the protected area migrate outward and replenish neighboring unprotected reefs.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Costa's proposed spillover mechanism?

- A: GPS tagging of fish within the MPA showed that a significant proportion of tagged individuals regularly crossed the MPA boundary and took up residence on adjacent unprotected reefs, and the density of tagged fish on those reefs decreased with distance from the boundary
- B: Fish species diversity was higher inside the MPA than on reefs outside the MPA, regardless of distance from the boundary
- C: The coral reef habitat adjacent to the MPA was structurally similar in quality and complexity to the reef habitat inside the protected area
- D: Fishing activity around the MPA had increased over the past decade as local fishers recognized the area as a productive zone

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Costa claims fish from the MPA migrate outward. A directly tracks individual fish crossing the boundary AND shows density decreasing with distance -- exactly what spillover predicts. B shows diversity differences but not movement. C shows similar habitat (a necessary condition) but not actual migration. D describes fishing behavior, not fish movement. TRICK: 'Spillover' is a movement claim. Movement claims require movement data -- direct tracking of individuals crossing the relevant boundary.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Psychologist Marcus Falk conducted a study in which adults experiencing high levels of anxiety were assigned to begin a daily journaling practice. After eight weeks, participants reported a 35 percent reduction in self-reported anxiety symptoms. Falk concluded that daily journaling is an effective intervention for reducing anxiety.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Falk's conclusion?

A: Participants who journaled more consistently -- writing entries on at least six days per week -- reported greater anxiety reduction than participants who journaled on fewer than four days per week

B: A control group of adults with equally high initial anxiety levels who were placed on a waitlist and did not journal also experienced a 30 percent reduction in anxiety symptoms over the same eight-week period

C: Several participants reported that they found the journaling task tedious and stopped engaging with it meaningfully after the first three weeks

D: The anxiety measure used in the study was a well-validated self-report scale that has been shown in previous research to reliably track changes in anxiety over time

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Falk credits journaling for the 35 percent anxiety reduction. B shows a control group that did NOT journal experienced nearly the same reduction (30 percent). This suggests the improvement reflects natural regression to the mean -- people recruited at peak anxiety tend to improve regardless of intervention. A actually strengthens (dose-response). D validates the measurement. TRICK: When participants are recruited at extreme symptom levels, natural fluctuation (regression to the mean) will produce apparent improvement even without treatment. A control group receiving no intervention is essential to detect this.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Physicist Amira Sayed observed a short-lived particle in a high-energy collision experiment. The particle existed for only 10^{-23} seconds before decaying. Sayed proposed that the observed particle is not a fundamental particle but a composite state -- a temporary bound configuration of two known lighter particles, a tau meson and a sigma baryon. If Sayed's model is correct, the composite particle's mass should equal the combined rest mass of a tau meson and a sigma baryon, and it should decay exclusively into those two constituent particles.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Sayed's composite-state model?

A: The particle was produced at a collision energy consistent with the threshold energy needed to create any particle of its observed mass, regardless of whether it is fundamental or composite

B: Theoretical calculations showed that a composite state formed from a tau meson and a sigma baryon would be unstable and would decay in approximately 10^{-23} seconds, consistent with the observed lifetime

C: Precise measurements confirmed that the particle's mass was within 0.1 percent of the combined rest mass of a tau meson and a sigma baryon, and analysis of every recorded decay event showed the particle decayed exclusively into exactly one tau meson and one sigma baryon, with no other decay channels observed

D: Other composite particles formed from pairs of known particles have been previously observed in similar high-energy collision experiments

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Sayed's model makes TWO specific predictions: (1) mass equals tau + sigma combined mass, and (2) it decays into exactly those two particles. C confirms BOTH with high precision (0.1 percent mass match, every decay event). B is tempting (correct lifetime) but matches only one prediction, and lifetime alone could be coincidental. A is neutral for either model. TRICK: When a hypothesis generates multiple independent, quantitatively precise predictions, confirming all of them simultaneously is far stronger support than confirming any single one.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Agricultural economist Jun Watanabe studied farms in a semi-arid region that adopted a new drip irrigation system. Watanabe compared crop yields during the first year of drip irrigation use with yields from the same farms during the previous year, when they used traditional flood irrigation. Watanabe found that drip-irrigated farms produced 25 percent higher yields and concluded that drip irrigation is significantly more effective than flood irrigation at maximizing crop output in semi-arid conditions.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Watanabe's conclusion?

A: Drip irrigation systems require a higher initial capital investment than flood irrigation systems, which may limit adoption among smaller farms

B: Some farmers who adopted drip irrigation also switched to a different crop variety that was better suited to drip watering methods

C: The farms in the study were representative of the broader semi-arid region in terms of soil composition, elevation, and average temperatures

D: Regional rainfall records show that the year in which drip irrigation was used received 40 percent more precipitation than the previous year in which flood irrigation was used, and precipitation is the single strongest predictor of crop yield in the region

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Watanabe compares Year 1 (flood) with Year 2 (drip). D shows Year 2 had 40 percent more rain, and rain is the strongest yield predictor. The yield increase likely came from better weather, not the irrigation system. B is a reasonable confound but less quantitatively devastating than D. A addresses adoption barriers, not effectiveness. TRICK: Before-and-after comparisons without controls are vulnerable to any variable that changes between the two periods. Weather is the classic temporal confound in agricultural studies.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Anthropologist Leila Haddad studied decorative patterns on pottery from five ancient villages in the Jordan Valley, dated to approximately 4000 BCE. Haddad observed that each village produced pottery with a distinctive set of geometric motifs not found on pottery from other villages. Haddad proposed that the decorative patterns served as markers of clan or village identity, enabling community members to signal group affiliation through their material culture.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Haddad's proposal?

A: Burial sites within each village contained pottery exclusively matching that village's decorative pattern, while pottery found at inter-village trading sites contained a mixture of all five villages' patterns, and individuals buried with 'foreign' pottery patterns showed skeletal evidence of having relocated from another village

B: The clay used to produce pottery in all five villages was chemically identical, sourced from the same riverbed deposit in the valley

C: The geometric motifs on the pottery bore no resemblance to natural objects and appeared to be entirely abstract in design

D: Pottery production in the Jordan Valley increased substantially between 4500 and 3500 BCE, reflecting a period of population growth and economic development in the region

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Haddad claims the patterns marked clan/village identity. A provides three-part evidence: (1) burials contain only home-village pottery, (2) trading sites mix all patterns, and (3) people buried with 'foreign' patterns were migrants. This proves the patterns tracked group membership. B shows shared clay (irrelevant to decoration function). C describes the motifs but not their social role. TRICK: 'Identity marker' claims require evidence that the marker correlates with group membership across multiple contexts (domestic, trade, burial, migration).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Management consultant Femi Adeyemi analyzed productivity data from a technology company that offered employees the option to work from home. Adeyemi found that employees who chose to work remotely completed 15 percent more tasks per week than employees who continued working in the office. Adeyemi concluded that working from home increases employee productivity, and recommended that the company expand its remote work program.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Adeyemi's conclusion?

- A: Employees who worked from home reported higher job satisfaction and lower stress levels than their in-office counterparts
- B: Employees who chose to work remotely were disproportionately senior staff members with more years of experience, higher baseline performance ratings, and roles that required less in-person collaboration than the roles held by employees who remained in the office
- C: The technology company provided remote employees with the same computing equipment, software tools, and technical support available to in-office employees
- D: Several other technology companies that have implemented remote work programs have reported similar increases in measured task completion rates among remote employees

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Adeyemi concludes remote work increases productivity. B reveals that remote workers were senior, higher-performing, and in less collaborative roles -- they were already more productive before going remote. The 15 percent advantage reflects WHO chose remote work, not WHERE they worked. C rules out an equipment confound (strengthening the comparison). D shows a pattern elsewhere but with the same self-selection problem. TRICK: When employees self-select into a work arrangement, pre-existing differences between groups explain the outcome. The same high performers would likely outperform in any setting.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Geologist Astrid Lindqvist examined a deep canyon in central Iceland that cuts through a basalt plateau. The prevailing theory holds that the canyon was carved gradually by the river that currently flows through it over approximately 500,000 years. Lindqvist proposed an alternative: the canyon was formed rapidly -- within days or weeks -- by a catastrophic glacial outburst flood (jokulhlaup) approximately 9,000 years ago, when a glacial lake drained suddenly beneath an ice cap.

Which finding, if true, would most directly support Lindqvist's catastrophic-flood hypothesis over the gradual-erosion theory?

A: The river currently flowing through the canyon has a relatively low flow volume that geomorphological models indicate would require over one million years to erode the observed volume of basalt, far exceeding the 500,000-year estimate

B: Glacial outburst floods of the magnitude Lindqvist proposes have been documented in Iceland's historical record, with the most recent occurring in 1996

C: The canyon walls contain distinctive features found exclusively in flood-carved landscapes -- including smooth, scalloped erosion surfaces and massive boulder deposits perched high above the current river level -- and sediment cores from the canyon floor show a single thick layer of flood-deposited gravel dated to approximately 9,000 years ago with no evidence of incremental sediment buildup below it

D: The basalt plateau through which the canyon is cut was formed by volcanic eruptions approximately 2 million years ago, providing sufficient time for either gradual or catastrophic erosion to have occurred

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Lindqvist claims a rapid catastrophic flood, not gradual erosion. C provides three independent lines of evidence: (1) flood-specific wall features, (2) massive boulders above the current river (impossible from slow erosion), and (3) a single flood-gravel layer dated to 9,000 years ago with NO incremental buildup beneath it. A weakens the gradual theory but does not confirm the flood alternative. B shows such floods can happen but not that one happened HERE. TRICK: When competing with a gradual process, a catastrophic-event hypothesis needs evidence of features that ONLY form rapidly and CANNOT result from slow accumulation.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Evidence (Support, Weaken)

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Education economist Sonia Ortiz studied school districts that raised teacher starting salaries by 20 percent between 2015 and 2020. Ortiz found that student test scores in these districts improved by an average of 7 percentile points over the five-year period. Ortiz concluded that raising teacher pay directly improves student outcomes because higher salaries attract more talented candidates to the teaching profession.

Which finding, if true, would most directly weaken Ortiz's conclusion?

A: Districts that raised salaries experienced slightly higher rates of teacher retention than districts that did not, reducing the disruption caused by annual staff turnover

B: The teacher candidates hired after the salary increase scored, on average, no higher on subject-matter competency examinations than candidates hired before the increase

C: Student test scores in districts that did not raise teacher salaries also improved modestly during the same period, though by a smaller margin

D: The districts that raised teacher salaries did so as part of comprehensive reform packages that simultaneously introduced rigorous new hiring criteria, structured mentoring programs for new teachers, redesigned evaluation systems with performance incentives, and reduced maximum class sizes by 20 percent

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Ortiz credits higher salaries for better outcomes via attracting talent. D shows the salary increase was bundled with hiring reforms, mentoring, new evaluations, AND smaller classes. Any combination of these could drive the 7-point gain, making it impossible to credit salaries specifically. B is also strong (new hires were no more talented, challenging the mechanism), but D is more comprehensive in showing multiple confounds. A actually supports the salary argument (retention).

TRICK: When a policy change is part of a reform package, every other reform in the package is a confound. The more changes bundled together, the less any single one can be credited.

END QUESTION